A pearly sky hung over the plains, grumbling at the rabbits who scrambled across the marsh. They stopped to nibble the berries that had fallen from the foxfruit bush before scurrying through the long spirals of rusty barbed wire that set the boundary of some long-forgotten property.

In the center of the vast, treeless stretch, an abandoned chapel to the Unadorned sank into the black earth. Its once white brick was stained with long black strands of filth. A horde of young frogs jumped from the murky water and attached themselves to the slimy walls, singing a raspy harmony with the thunder.

The submerged east corner of the chapel was overtaken by thorny heaps of ivy. Alongside deadly thorns bloomed the mourning flower, whose sticky sweet scent wafted over the marsh.

Clinging to the bent weather vane atop the chapel's cupola was a bright and dutiful tapestry spider named Tychus.

From this vantage point, he could see all the way to the edge of the marsh. Mud elk walked the perimeter where fish got trapped in shallow waters, and were easily skewered by the sword-like bone protrusions from their skulls. They hunted in pairs, each allowing the other to eat the fish that wriggled on the end of his antlers. Broad hooves prevented them from sinking into the mud, which was essential for the quick retreats from Kladramara, the giant long-snouted, blind crocodile who was as old as the marsh itself.

Tychus scanned the muddy waters and finally spotted her, looking thinner than ever. Her once lustrous scales were dull and cracked. Her yellow eyes betrayed a

hungry desperation. Hunting had become more difficult as she grew slower each year, and even the young and sickly elk starting evading her bite. They became less fearful by the day, wandering a little further into Kladramara's domain.

That worried Tychus, not only because he hated to see his friend suffer in her old age, but also because in greater numbers the mud elk would overfish the waters, they would devour the vegetation, they would stomp on frogs and rabbits and worst of all, they would bring the wolves again.

A crackling vein of lightning slashed the sky open and bled rain onto the marsh. Having saved his least favorite part of the assessment until last, Tychus steeled himself and entered the little belltower, then lowered himself on a thin black line into the flooded interior of the chapel.

Black water lapped against decaying pews. Tychus dropped onto the neck of a headless statue standing in an alcove, ran to the finger of its outstretched hand, and jumped over the ghoulfish swimming around the statue's ankles. He landed on the top edge of a pew in the last row and ran along it to the chapel's center, then hopped from pew to pew toward the front of the sanctuary.

Ghoulfish rose to the surface along the tops of the pews, inhaling Tychus' scent as he ran by. He scanned the water as he ran, spotting the floating limbs of at least three rotfairies who had been snatched out of the air, drowned, nibbled upon, and dismembered, though not necessarily in that order.

In retaliation, the rotfairies had left writhing

ghoulfish impaled on tiny spears around the edge of the altar. In the center of the altar was a ghastly pile of mud nests, riddled with holes and crowned with twisted spires that nearly reached the ceiling.

Tychus jumped to the altar, his glittering eyes scanning the rotfairy citadel. Though his venom could wither them in seconds, the fairies were wasp-minded and malicious, incapable of either empathy or forethought. They used their humanoid hands to craft and wield weapons, which put Tychus at a disadvantage. And though Tychus was ashamed to admit it even to himself, the awful faces they had evolved over the ages to both mimick and mock humanity both disgusted and terrified him.

Tychus stepped softly into the semicircle of nests before him, counting the holes that housed one or more working fairies

and the pupae who had been assigned to them. Fortunately, no fairies seemed to be present at the moment, but he shuddered as his passing disturbed the sleep in the broodhouse and dozens of larvae stuck together in one congealed mass cried out to him for food and attention.

Rotfairies were notoriously negligent toward their young, but knowing this didn't slow Tychus down as he rushed past the storehouse and eyeballed a three-week supply of rothoney. The pollen of the mourning flower already smelled unpleasant, but the final product emitted a rancid stench.

The fairies were never far from the pollen of the mourning flower. Its abundance allowed for lots of free time, which the rotfairies usually spent dueling or capturing and torturing lizards and insects. The tiny bones and remnants of

exoskeletons told Tychus their sadistic habits had not changed.

He breathed a sigh of relief at the realization that he would not have to meet any rotfairies today, jumped onto the east wall, and scurried over a broken windowpane back into the rain, under the cover of the ivy.

Launching himself from thistle to weed, he landed finally on the edge of the end of a dirt road that was quickly turning to mud. He ascended a tilting pole thirty feet to the top and stepped onto the black cable that stretched to the next pole, barely visible in the misty distance.

Tychus gripped the cable tightly, waiting patiently for the rain to stop hitting the line.

He scanned the rolling hills that rose above the fog to the east, now marred with

black squares of scorched earth. Humble farmhouses had been smashed to splinters by knights on a fool's errand for a holy trinket of some sort.

To the west was the source of the destruction - a city in the throes of madness, to Tychus' estimation.

And straight ahead along the line on which he sat was the road north. It led all the way to Ixlin, the witch township for which he worked.

The sky closed up and the rain softened. Tychus, having mentally prepared his report, gripped the cable with his two rear legs, tapping out a sort of Morse code with the other six, each with a different pattern of dots and dashes.

The vibrations Tychus tapped out on the cable alarmed a lazy bangbeetle resting in

the slack of the line; he jolted awake and ignited the volatile contents in his belly, exploding like a cannon. The echo shot through the tall grass, scrambling the rabbits and crows into an annoyed confusion.

Tychus, being a consummate professional, did not react; he simply added the occurrence to his report. His legs continued tapping out their polyrhythmic message with precision and enthusiasm without hesitation.

The coded pulses rode from pole to pole until they descended the first branching wire to a stone cottage nestled in foxfruit bushes.

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The home was hidden from the world by three everautumn trees growing in a

triangle around it - one on either side of the house, and the third rising from a little hill in the garden. The wet branches shed endless flame-colored leaves.

Three coats of black paint covered the cottage's few windows. Inside, the soft light from shaded lamps illuminated a cozy parlor. The forest green walls were cluttered with paintings in frames of various sizes, shapes, and materials, with none of them matching.

The ceiling was covered with a network of paper lanterns and strings of purple glass beads that tinkled softly from the subtle breeze slipping through the front door, which had been propped open by the weathered head of a statue.

A solitary ember burned from the ashes in the fireplace. A white long-haired cat slept

in front of it, refusing to accept that the fire had gone out.

The message crawled the line from ceiling to floor, into a black rotary phone that stood on its little table with eight legs, much like Tychus'.

The telephone jangled enthusiastically until six year-old Ylla lifted its receiver. She raised it with both hands to her ear and stared blankly at the wall, absorbing the patterns of six distinct tones warbling dots and dashes until the message had ended.

Ylla had developed a recent interest in the intricacies of phone etiquette and safety ever since her friend Pyna's mother was infected with a flatterworm. As was the parasite's habit, it entered the host's ear directly from the line, usually during a long conversation. It sat in her inner ear and whispered sweet nothings. Pyna said her

mother would blush and say thank you while doing the dishes, and only went to see the nanomancer to have it removed after her husband insisted. Ylla thought she wouldn't mind having a flatterworm.

She replaced the receiver and ran to the back door. She turned the knob and let it swing open while she held on, pulling her forward until she was leaning over the first of the five steps to the garden on her tiptoes.

Her mother, her older brother Flick, and their helper Balo were working in the garden. Her sister Dyetta, the eldest, was sternly hanging linens on the line.

Radeka Endriver wore her black hair in a loose bun. The wind pulled the strands of silver from her temples. She wiped her soiled gloves on the front of her coveralls.

"Ylla, don't swing on the door!" she said, then sighed as her daughter leapt over the steps and landed on her knees.

"I just had to tell your brother to stop doing that," she scolded. "Did you listen carefully?"

Ylla nodded, grinning.

"Good! Go ahead."

"The elk pop'lation is increasing and overfishing. Rotfairies are still feuding with ghoulfish, but their pop'lation is steady. But most... um... most importantly... um..."

"Ylla, I told you to write it down if you can't remember."

"I know, I forgot. And somebody is dying."

"Ylla! Who is dying?"

"Um..."

"Kladramara?"

Ylla smiled and nodded, but the smile faded when she saw her mother's look of concern.

"Who is that, mama?"

Her mother looked toward the southern marsh.

"She's the queen of the swamp!" bellowed Flick. He dropped the rake he was holding and kicked a pile of wet leaves in his sister's direction.

"You're going to have to rake all that back up," Dyetta smirked under the clothesline.

Flick shrugged, shaking bits of leaf from

his dirty blond hair. "She bit off Balo's finger!" he announced, pointing at the young man's hand. "Right, Balo?"

"Flick!" Radeka chided.

"It's okay, Mrs. Endriver," Balo smiled, returning his attention to Flick. "That's right! But Kladramara was really after..." he crouched to Flick's eye level and wriggled the nine fingers of his right hand at the boy, then shouted "my guts!" and feigned a swipe at the boy's midsection. Flick squealed with laughter.

"Balo."

"Yes, ma'am." his smile dropped and he matched her solemn tone.

"I'm going to making dinner for some guests this evening. Just a few old friends from the Council."

"Yes ma'am, I can assist."

"No, the girls will help me. Ylla needs to practice her cooking skills. Why don't you take Flick with you on your errands in town?"

"In Ixlin?" Flick beamed.

"Balo, I'll give you a little extra so you can both get something to eat while you're out. And you can take that awful necklace Ms. May gifted me. Resell it for what you can and keep the money."

"Thank you ma'am," Balo gave a little bow.

"Mother!" Dyetta protested. "That's very discourteous. Ms. May's sister died only a week ago!"

"Yes, and Ms. May's sister had a big collection of gaudy shit from Aureline. Ms. May didn't want it, either," Radeka muttered, removing her gardening gloves. "And don't be a brat, Dyetta. Go start chopping the vegetables."

"Yes, Mother," Dyetta hissed, dripping with teenage attitude as she pushed Ylla aside and stomped up the stairs.

"Yeah, don't be a brat!" echoed Ylla, scowling at her sister.

Flick looked up at Balo. "Let's get out of here."

Balo winked. "We'll be heading out now, Mrs. Endriver, if that's alright."

"Yes, that's alright." She dropped to a knee to pull Flick to her, holding him tightly for a moment. "Be good. Be safe. I love you," she

said.

"I love you too, Mom," Flick replied, casting an eyeroll in Balo's direction. "Let's go!"

Balo and Flick grabbed their respective walking sticks as they passed through the house and out the front door, leaving the women to prepare for an event which Flick was happy to miss.

A few paces from the front door and they were on the road into town. Flick breathed deeply, relieved to be out of his mother's sight.

Flick took long steps on the road to town, trying to keep up with Balo. Dull yellow grass stretched to the horizon in every direction under a blank white sky. The cool air tasted sweet and metallic.

"H-yah!" Flick shouted, holding his walking

stick like a sword and jabbing it at Balo, who parried effortlessly.

"Nice try," Balo snorted, countering with a wide swing that Flick ducked, jabbing his stick into Balo's ribs as he rose.

"Oof! Well done, squire! Knighthood is in your future," Balo laughed.

"Why didn't you become a knight?"

"Well, if you must know," he parried another thrust, "it's because they're a bunch of idiots."

"Because they wouldn't let you in?" Flick asked, swinging his stick.

"No," Balo sidestepped. "Because they destroy crops and kill innocent people."

"Really?"

"Haven't you seen... look, come here," Balo left the road and jogged up a little hill a few paces to the east. Flick chased after him to the top.

Balo pointed toward several acres of scorched earth smoldering in the distance.

"Do you remember Anglen Sweetroot? Your mother used to buy his carrots and potatoes and onions. Her stew was always best with his vegetables, do you remember? Well, the knights burned his fields, his barn, his house. As for Anglen himself, who knows? Everyone's afraid to go looking for him while the knights are still around."

Flick nodded, brow furrowed. "I remember him. Let's go, Balo, we have to see if he's still alive!"

"Not so fast, squire," Balo swung out his stick to block Flick's advance. "We already have a quest in town, remember?"

"But-"

"I know. It's a terrible thing, but it can't be undone. And it's not safe. When the wind lulled last evening, the sound of their awful drunken singing floated across the plains. They're still looking for something."

"Looking for what?"

"Nothing that matters," Balo shrugged, and led Flick back onto the road. "Come on, squire. I'll buy you a whiskey."

"Really?"

"Of course not... maybe a small one."

Flick's eyes rose to follow the black cable

that ran parallel to the road, hung loose in the white sky by wooden poles spaced evenly, crackling with strange messages. In the distance ahead, the cable reached a pole at the edge of Ixlin and fanned out into a messy array of spokes that stretched across the town.

One of the lines connected the five poles that ascended the bluff on the east side of the town and climbed to the tallest point in Ixlin - the steepled roof of Murkwood Manor, which had been hidden by a thick copse of trees along the ridge, until their recent and sudden removal exposed its blank walls.

The structure was vast and breathtakingly hideous. Dozens of floors of pale, mildew-stained concrete were stacked upon one another, forming an unsettling wall that seemed to be leaning over the edge,

windows like a hundred black, scowling eyes.

The black cable penetrated the manor. It climbed between the walls and stretched across the study and out onto the balcony, pulled taut. It had been tied into a noose, and a leathery skinned old sailor who stood on the railing was tightening it around his neck.

He hesitated. The long wisps of grey hair that protruded from his temple danced in the wind. He felt the cable around his neck pulse with irregular vibrations. The sailor stood frozen for a moment, fingertips on the line around his throat, interpreting the strange message.

The old sailor's eyes lit up. He removed the noose and returned to the desk in his study, rifling through its drawers until he found a handrawn map.

He traced a path into the marshes with a shaking finger, grabbed a journal, and began scribbling notes on a new page.

A wry smile crossed his face as he ripped the page from the journal and dashed down the hall to one of his many barricaded wings. He shoved tables and chairs and a dresser aside to reveal a metal door twice his height. He yanked its handle with all his wiry might and threw it open, paying no attention to the glass case beside it that toppled and shattered, scattering nautical artifacts across the floor.

Beyond the door was a tiny bare room. In its center stood a seven foot tall statue of clay. Its form was crude. Atop broad sloping shoulders arose a neck that became a head with little transition. The

face was an amateurishly rendered set of two deep, asymmetrical eye holes and a wide slash beneath them.

The sailor took a few shuffled steps toward the clay golem as if it might suddenly spring to life. He stood on his toes and held his breatn. His shaking fingers tucked the ripped page into the slash until the golem's mouth was filled with instruction. The sailor gave the golem an affectionate pat on its fat clay belly and dashed from the room down the hall, leaving the door open.

The clay golem stood very still. It was very good at this; it rested in utter serenity knowing that it was clay, and clay never needed to be or do anything else, unless it was properly motivated. But it had been fed fine, buttery paper inscribed with the fine, buttery words of its master. The commands were sweet to the taste as it

rolled them over its clay tongue. But as sweet as it was to receive instruction, it was much sweeter to obey them.

...

"It's bad luck to look at it," Balo said, interrupting Flick's daydream and making him jump.

"What is it?" Flick asked.

"It's the devil's house."

"I want to go!"

Balo laughed. "I think I'd need your mother's permission for that.

"Heyo Balo!" an irritating sing-song voice came from ahead. "Thought that was you. Didja hear about Kest?" A young man around Balo's age was coming toward

them. Long, discolored hair hung limply on either side of his gaunt face. Flick glanced at Balo, whose eyes flashed with recognition and annoyance.

"Hey there, Rubic." Balo smiled with his mouth but not his eyes. "No, I've not seen Keste since the time you both ditched me on that haul job."

Rubic squinted and scratched at his thin, patchy beard. "Let you keep all the money though, yeah?"

"Yeah. Forget it. What's new with Keste?"

"Knighted," Rubic sneered, revealing nasty little rows of round, grey teeth. "Believe it?"

"Wow. Well, yeah, I believe it. He trained hard."

"And I didn't?" Rubic squared his shoulders.

Flick released a small but audible scoff. Rubic glared at him.

"Who's the little shit?" he snarled.

"Oh fuck off, Rubic. This is Flick Endriver."

"Ah, your boss lady's son," Rubic said. "Is she still as sexy as she was at last ceremony?"

"Don't be disgusting," Balo said.

"I have something for you," Rubic replied, ignoring the chastisement.

"Oh?" Balo asked. He glanced at Flick.

"Yeah," Rubic answered, suddenly looking serious. "Meet me in Third Alley in an hour." He turned with an obnoxious flourish and left the path, walking through tall grass toward a small cabin on the edge of

town.

"Who was that?" Flick asked, scowling at Rubic as he left. "What does he have for you?"

"Rubic is just an idiot from my school days. He works for the local blacksmith, so I paid him for a work tool I need."

"What kind of tool?"

"Just something for the yard. Come on, Flick, pick up the pace! Can you smell that?" Balo lifted his nose to the sky and inhaled deeply.

Flick's mouth watered at the smell of smoked pork. He pointed at a pillar of smoke rising ahead. Balo nodded.

"Basher's got a pig on the spinner. You

hungry already?"

Flick started to say yes, but was immediately distracted as they entered Ixlin.

Straight ahead, an assortment of chains, knives, and other forged pieces hung in a neat row on the rail around the blacksmith's yard, glistening in the sunlight. The blacksmith retrieved a bar of red-hot metal from the furnace. Adjacent to the little smithy, carefully carved polearms with spear heads and curved blades leaned against a woodworker's shop.

To the other side stood a tall, narrow house with no roof; an ornate iron cage extended 30 feet above it, and contained a colorful aviary that erupted with warbles and bird songs that used a strange

musical scale. One of the caged creatures released a reptilian scream.

Just beyond the aviary was a windowless building with a painted sign reading "Affordable Children." Below it, a smaller sign read "Defanging service available."

On the lawn beside the path, a small crowd was gathering around two men who were exchanging insults and rolling up their sleeves. One reached into a leather pouch on his belt while the other placed a wooden box on the ground and opened it. Each of them raised an open palm to display a grotesque creature. Gasps and spurts of applause went through the crowd as the men raised their arms for all to see. A jolt of visceral revulsion shot down Flick's spine as one of the things turned in his direction and revealed a ghastly face that twisted with pain, or fiendish glee, or both.

"What are those?" whispered Flick to Balo.

"Rotfairies," Balo answered with a grimace. "It's said that they are somewhere between human beings and wasps. They eat rotting flesh and smell like death. Disgusting things. But even the worst creature doesn't deserve this," he gestured toward them.

The rotfairies leapt at each other and were jerked back by gold chains that leashed each to a ring on its owner's finger. The crowd laughed, then began to cheer as the men took a step toward one another, putting the rotfairies in fighting range. They grappled in mid-air, ripping at each other's black wings with short, piercing shrieks.

Balo's hand went over Flick's eyes. "It's a horrible thing," he said, and led him past the spectacle into a dark little tavern.

Sawdust covered the floor. A half-dozen sweaty drunks squinted and cursed the light. Balo shut the door quickly behind him. As Flick's eyes adjusted, he glanced around at the tired eyes watching him from every corner of the room.

"Paying customers only, " the stout red man behind the bar grunted.

"I intend to pay," said Balo.

"No hard drink for the little ones. At least not ones I don't recognize. Last time I got an earful from Eleka after her son vomited on the cat."

Balo pointed at a bottle on the shelf behind the man. "How about a cup of swamp cider for the boy? A draught of black barrel for me."

"Swamp cider for the boy?" the bartender echoed, and laughter rolled across the room.

Balo pulled Flick to a stool. He tried to straddle it like Balo did, but his legs were too short. A small crowd was gathering behind them, fully focused on the cup of amber liquid that the bartender poured and slid across the bar. One of them hoisted Flick onto the stool, saying "You gotta take it down in one draught, boy!"

Balo leaned over to whisper to Flick. "Drink it all at once. When you burp, exhale sharp and quick, like you're shooting a dart out of a blowgun. You remember how to do that, right?"

Flick nodded, wide-eyed. The small crowd started clapping rhythmically. The drunks in the back of the bar stomped their feet and slammed their fists on their tables,

faster and faster until Flick had drained the cup. A low rumble arose from his stomach.

"Aim away from me," Balo suggested nonchalantly.

Flick lurched forward. The crowd scattered. Something was coming up. He felt like he had to belch, throw up, cough, and sneeze all at once. Instead, an involuntary bark escaped his throat alongside a wad of black phlegm that bounced down the bar, leaving a dark, viscous trail.

The drunks in the back were howling with laughter.

Flick watched the end of the bar in horror as the contents of his stomach turned over and flicked slime from its unfolding limbs.

"Congratulations, squire!" Balo grinned. "Your first oilfrog."

It blinked away the last of the slime and stared at Flick with shiny black eyes ringed with gold. It launched itself in one hop from the slime to Flick's chest and scrambled with soft sticky fingers up his throat before affixing itself to the nape of his neck, wrapping its hind legs wide and clutching two tufts of Flick's hair with its front legs.

Flick could feel the frog's tiny racing heart pressed against his neck gradually slow down as its grip on his hair loosened slightly.

"He likes you," Balo laughed. "You're lucky."

Flick and Balo exited the bar into blinding daylight. The oilfrog slid down to Flick's

shoulder, stretching out its thin body.

Balo was glad to see that the rotfairy fighter crowd had dispersed and hoped that Flick had forgotten about it. "Hungry?" he asked tentatively.

Flick nodded enthusiastically. Balo led him toward the stall that was the source of the delicious smell of roasting pork and ordered a slab for each of them, with a scoop of potatoes from a massive iron skillet that sizzled loudly. Balo set a small stack of silver coins on the table, and the cook handed them a pair of steaming wooden bowls.

Balo leaned against the wall of the stall, watching the sparks from the blacksmith's anvil, peeling off long strips of pork with his teeth.

A brunette girl passed by the stall, batting

her long eyelashes at Balo, seemingly unfazed by his lack of table manners. Noticing this, Flick leaned against the wall and began to eat his food the same way.

A gentle breeze carried the smoke and the sound from the nearby forge into the trees that towered above. Balo glanced at the frog on Flick's shoulder. "He's looking a little swollen. You'll need to milk him."

"I need to what?" Flicked asked, aghast.

"Milk him. Give him a squeeze."

Flick stared at Balo, waiting for his straight face to break into a grin, but instead he picked his teeth and repeated "Squeeze him. They require it every now and then. In the wild, they periodically jump on each other's backs."

Flick took the oilfrog from his shoulder and held him in both hands. Little iridescent beads were forming on its back. It licked its eyeball expectantly.

"Go ahead," Balo coaxed. "Not too hard."

Flick squeezed the frog as gently as he could. Dozens of tiny streams of oil squirted from its back in all directions, causing it to relax languidly into his palms.

"Disgusting!" Flick exclaimed, laughing.

"Isn't it? A juicy oilfrog opens the door to all sorts of mischief for a young squire."

"His name is Thaddeus," Flick announced.

"A fine name," Balo nodded.

Flick finished feeding himself with one hand while holding Thaddeus up stuff the

other to catch the flies that were drawn to the meat.

When all three stomachs were full and a sleepy and relatively clean Thaddeus was tucked safely into Flick's front pocket, they complimented the cook and continued on their way to the shops.

"This part of town is a little more lively," Balo warned. "Stay right by me so you don't get lost."

They followed the path that curled around the aviary. It widened into a boulevard made of bricks painted nine shades between purple and blue. Some of the cracks had recently been filled with a concrete that glittered with diamond dust. Intricate latticework that twisted into Celtic knots bordered the path and formed a domed tunnel. Lush ivy climbed the lattice and unfurled clumps of deep violet flowers

that dangled above like grapes.

They stepped into a round plaza centered around a towering marble fountain. An obelisk jutted from its center and served as a sundial, casting a long narrow shadow halfway between a golden 3 and 4 that were etched into the edge of the circle etched into the stonework on which dozens of people walked, mostly ignoring one another, tending to their own business.

Balo pulled Flick aside just in time to avoid being bowled over by a cluster of gray-bearded men who wore dark cloaks lined with tiny bells that jingled as they walked. They smelled like smoke and roses.

A cluster of narrow storefronts faced the plaza. A semicircle of long tables and stalls lined with Moroccan rugs formed an outdoor market. The tables were laden with previously studied leatherbound

books tucked with handwritten notes and diagrams, rows of intricate animal face masks carved from wood and stone, racks lined with tinctures in tiny colored glass bottles, and an apparatus that appeared to be for holding and drilling into a human head.

A pale woman with silver eyeshadow and a flowing robe that matched directed three tiny hummingbirds in a carefully orchestrated task; they each carried a segment of a long thread that they pushed and pulled through a hanging, incomplete tapestry, weaving with incredible speed to the delight of the children who watched.

"Here," Balo handed Flick the ugly necklace his mother had been gifted. "You may be able to sell it over there. Don't forget to haggle. You know what that means, right?"

Flick nodded. He didn't.

"I've got to meet Rubic. Stay in the plaza; I'll be back in a moment."

Before he could object, Balo was gone. Flick approached the tables, clutching the necklace nervously.

A stocky man with a limp mustache eyed Flick as he straightened his rows of jewelry. "What do you have there?" the man asked.

"I want to sell this," Flick stated resolutely.

"Hmm," the man peered over his glasses. "Let's see." Flick handed it to him with hesitation.

The merchant raised it to his face, peering over his little round glasses. His face flashed with recognition, then he released

a sound somewhere between scream and whimper. "My necklace! My work! A beautiful piece from my wintergold collection. Who have you stolen this from? She's a lady of means and taste! Who? Did you mug her or burgle her house? Answer me, damn you!"

An angry vein on the man's forehead throbbed. Flick began to mumble a quiet defense, but the man bellowed across the plaza: "Thief! Tiny filthy thief child!"

Flick felt eyes from all directions. He found himself running before he made the conscious decision to do so, and once he had ducked into a quiet, hedge-lined avenue and felt that he was out of sight, hot tears rolled down his face. He dragged his sleeve over his eyes and sniffled. Balo shouldn't have left him. This was his fault. He scowled and thought of how he'd yell at

Balo for leaving him. But then he considered that Balo might yell back, might call him a little fool for running and a coward for not defending himself. Flick suppressed a childish sob and walked faster, wishing only to get far away from the plaza.

This part of town was quieter and older. The hedge ended where a tight row of tiny stone structures began.

Flick's pace slowed, and Thaddeus crawled up his neck, sympathetically dabbing his sticky little feet at Flick's tears.

A thin wisp of a woman with knee-length jet black hair was sweeping the doorstep of her shop. She spotted Flick before he saw her. He cast his wet, red eyes toward the ground but it was too late, she had seen him crying.

"Don't be sad, little boy. The Dying Man dies for you, if you let him. Have you let him?"

The woman's pale, wide-open made Flick nervous, but he wasn't sure why. Thaddeus burrowed into the thicket that was Flick's hair.

"I don't want anyone to die for me," Flick said.

"Blasphemy! He must! He is the Dying Man, dying is what he does!"

Seeing Flick's blank expression, she grumbled something about his upbringing, but beckoned him into her shop. Flick felt it would be rude not to enter, so he followed her.

The interior of the shop was cavernous, lit

only by a series of tall, fat white candles spaced evenly across the wooden shelves.

She led Flick to a display on a round table. In its center was a miniature tree no taller than nine inches with a figure attached to it. Flick approached, his eyes still adjusting to the low light, focusing on the little figure until he could see it clearly. It looked like a little man in torn clothing, wet with sweat and blood.

Flick thought this was a very strange art piece until the little man directly in front of him lifted his head and coughed blood.

Flick suppressed a scream. "It's alive?"

"Why, surely!" she grinned ghoulishly. "He is the Dying Man, not the Dead Man!"

Flick took another step toward the tiny

man.

"Well, not THE Dying Man, of course. This is a personal model for home use. My own innovation! This is the prototype. A living miniature for your devotion and enjoyment. It will be sold as a set that includes a little sponge for mopping his little brow, and a little spear for inflicting little wounds!"

"You mean to stab him? I would never do that," said Flick.

"But you must," she approached him from behind, her candlight shadow climbing the wall. She placed her hand on his shoulder and he tensed.

"You must be clean to enter the Great Garden," she intoned. "In order to do so, you must cast your filth upon he who dies for us! He offers himself as sacrifice. Take the spear and do what we do best, so that

he can make your dirty spirit pure!"

"Huh?"

"Ignorant boy! Stay right here!" Her wooden heels clacked away on the stone floor.

The tiny, bloodied head on which Flick's eyes had remained transfixed rose again. This time he spoke.

"She's going upstairs to get the Book of Order," the tiny man said. "You have to get me out of here. This is my only chance."

"How? Your arms are nailed to a tree."

"You'll have to pull me off of it. Make it quick, so they rip right through. Otherwise you'll tear my arms off."

"Maybe I can pull out the nails," Flick hesitated.

"There's no time! I'll live, boy, I promise! Do it now! I'm begging you! I'm being tortured! I'll give you whatever you want! Gold, women, wine... she's coming back! Do it!"

The sound of the woman's wooden heels drew closer. "I hope that's a filthy confession I'm hearing! Don't forget to draw blood as soon as you've shared your awful secrets."

The man's eyes widened in terror and his bloody bearded chin quivered as he watched her approach. "You'll be a hero from this day forth, boy! Now!"

Flick suppressed every memory of his mother directing him to be as gentle as possible with small, injured things, gripped the man around the middle like a doll and yanked and turned to run in one motion.

The man screamed. Flick ran for the door, brushed against the woman's frail body, and knocked her to the ground.

Flick escaped into the sunlight and placed the little man in his shirt pocket. The man's face was twisted with pain. He tore his rags to wrap around his mutilated hands and curled up defensively. A dot of blood stained through Flick's shirt.

"Don't stop! Keep moving!" the little man shouted through his teeth. "Take the next left!" Flick veered left when the avenue forked, and followed the tiny man's directions as he led them off the path into the tall grass, toward a copse of silver oak.

"Wait!" the man said. "This is close enough. Get down low."

Flick obeyed and dropped to his knees in the tall grass.

"Hold me up so I can see," the little man commanded, crawling out of Flick's pocket and into the palm of his hand. He raised his arm so the man could see above the grass.

He froze in place, staring at what looked like a swarm of large insects darting through the distant trees.

Flick glanced up at the man standing in his hand. His bare back was covered in cuts and scars, but none of them were nearly as big or ghastly as the two that ran down each shoulder blade.

"What are you looking at?"

"My family," the little man replied.

Flick squinted his eyes at the flying creatures and back at the man standing in

his palm and released a gasp.

"You... had wings?"

The man didn't answer.

"Don't you want to go back to them?"

The man didn't answer. He turned to face Flick and said "I can't. Put me back in your pocket."

Flick obeyed, and took him back to the path.

"Place me on your open palm, boy. I'd like to face you." Flick complied and the tiny man continued. "I owe you an explanation. But first, thank you for saving me. My name is Zeet."

"I'm Flick. Why don't you want to go back to your family?"

"I am a member of the Seelie Court - a fairy."

"Like a rotfairy?"

"No!" Zeet grimaced. "Nothing like a rotfairy. True fairies are quite clever and beautiful. When we're intact, that is. That bitch caught me in a net one morning while I was gathering berries. Sadistic cunt tore my wings off. My beautiful wings. God damn it. Do you have a smoke?"

Flick shook his head.

Zeet sighed but continued. "We are not like you. We can withstand a great deal, and we heal very quickly. My hands will reassemble themselves. In a week, all these cuts and scars will be gone. But my wings will never grow back. We take great pride in our gossamer wings. When a lady

fairy seeks out a mate, she looks for the strongest, most lovely pair of wings. To lose our wings is to lose everything. I could never go back to them. The shame and humiliation would be unbearable."

"But won't they take care of you?"

"Oh, of course! But don't you see, I will always be an invalid to them. I will always be broken, and they will pity me. I am too proud for pity. And I won't be a burden. Except to you, of course," he half-smiled.

"You won't be a burden," said Flick. "You aren't much bigger than Thaddeus."

"Thaddeus?"

Hearing his new name, the oil frog climbed out of Flick's hair and hopped onto his extended arm.

"Mud chicken!" Zeet screamed, and ran to the end of Flick's middle finger. Thaddeus' tongue shot out and grabbed Zeet's ankle.

"Bad frog!" Flick scolded, snatching him off his arm with the other hand. Warm oil streamed through his fingers.

"I'll not keep company with the mud chicken, boy," Zeet huffed.

"I won't let Thaddeus hurt you. You'll have to get along."

"Where do you live? To the south?"

"Umm..."

"Point your finger at home."

The hand holding the frog raised and pointed southwest. "It's... that way. I think."

"Fine. I won't trouble you much longer. Take me with you halfway home. I'll start a new life in a new grove."

"Oh no!" Flick gasped. "I forgot to stay in the plaza!" He jammed the fairy in his pocket and dashed back toward the plaza, past the Dying Man shop.

Flick's fear of angering Balo eclipsed his fear of the accusatory mob, but the latter had completely dissipated. The tables were cleared of their wares, and the few people still in the plaza were leaving.

As he paused to catch his breath, bitter anxiety rose in Flick's throat.

"Don't panic," the fairy said. "Who are you looking for?"

"Balo," Flick replied. "He works for my...

he's my friend."

Flick's eyes lit up as he remembered something. "Third Alley! That's where he's meeting his stupid friend."

"Ah, I know a shortcut!" said Zeet. "There's a stable behind the alchemist's. Me and the boys used to buzz through that shop and try not to get swatted. The storefront is right down there," he pointed.

Flick dashed to the alchemist's door, found it ajar, and slipped inside. The door brushed against a series of chimes that played a wistful chord.

Thaddeus arose from atop Flick's head to look around. Stacks of animal cages lined the walls from floor to ceiling. Small primates with round, protruding black eyes and long, shimmering white fur clung to the bars and sniffed the air as Flick came

closer.

A large, illuminated terrarium stood to the right. From underneath a thick floor of moss, foxlike creatures peeked out, then retreated. An elderly orb tortoise pulled a piece of leaf into its shell and curled into a perfect iridescent sphere before rolling into his little water reservoir.

To Flick's left, curling segments of copper piping connected a series of copper vessels, each adorned with a dial that twitched slightly. In every corner of the room were clusters of bottles, some full and some empty, all of them dusty.

"Who's that?" a voice bellowed. An imposing figure arose from a desk behind the copper vessels, broad-shouldered and bearded, with long black eyelashes rimmed with gold, adorned with an asymmetrical series of rings and bracelets

and bangles and a gauzy strapless gown. "Do you need help?"

"Yes, ma'am," Flick responded.

Her scowl softened into a soft smile. "Polite boy. Your clothes are provincial, but your heart is not. I'm Yrda, the local alchemistress. What brings you into my little emporium this evening?" She tapped one of the copper vessels with a black fingernail, glancing at the dials.

A burst of purple smoke spread across the ceiling, and smelled like cinnamon. Flick sneezed.

"Apologies," said Yrda, and used a scroll of parchment to wave the smoke away. "My little air freshener is a little strong for some noses. Tumpkin, my sweet demon," she pointed at a pudgy goblin-like creature sitting in the rafters.

"He flatulates at will. I employ him for this purpose. He eats a steady diet of rancid mutton and beets. It makes his gas smell divine." A wide, satisfied smile spread across the sweet demon's face.

"I'll let him go for a reasonable price," Yrda said, chuckling at Tumpkin's scowl.

"God's bottom, won't you let the boy speak?" Zeet exclaimed from Flick's pocket.

"Oh. A fairy," Yrda rolled the scroll tightly. "If you don't intend to buy anything, I'll have to ask you to leave.. or be swatted."

"We want to buy a horse!" Zeet exclaimed.

"I don't have any horses. I have mules."

"Mules! Even better. Let's take a look."

Yrda glanced at Flick skeptically, but Zeet added "don't worry about the boy. I handle the money. Fairy fortune, you know."

Yrda half-nodded with an arched eyebrow. "This way." She led them into the maze of shelves, snaking toward the other side of the room. Flick rushed to keep up.

"Yep, very important fairy project," Zeet continued, jostling in Flick's shirt pocket. "The boy is an able beast of burden for myself, but our entire tribe would like to migrate in luxury. I have patented a special carriage saddle that allows a whole gaggle of fairies to head south for the winter in comfort and style. I have a prototype to show off at next year's -"

"Here they are," Yrda interrupted as she swung open a pair of doors. The odor of dung floating in on the early evening air.

Three healthy mules brayed from the stables.

"Go!" Zeet hissed Flick, pointing to the alley just beyond the stable.

"These two are the same price, but the old one-" Yrda turned to face Flick as he awkwardly stepped past the stables. She cocked an eyebrow. "Where are you going?"

"I'm sorry, I have to-"

"Go!" yelled Zeet.

Flick ran for the alley.

"No more fairies in my shop or stables, damn it, you hear me?" Yrda shouted after them. "Tell all your fairy bastard friends!"

Flick barreled down the alley until he spotted two silhouettes shaped like Balo

and Rubric. They were speaking in hushed voices, facing the opposite direction. Balo was aiming a weapon down the alley. They didn't hear Flick until he bellowed "Hey, Balo!" from three feet behind them.

"Goddamnit!" Balo jolted and the weapon jumped in his hands with a crack that Flick felt in his chest. A small pyramid of glass bottles stood ten yards ahead, but it was a glass window of the tailor at the end of the alley that shattered.

"What the hell are you doing?" Balo scowled down at Flick. His eyes were wide and a vein throbbed in his forehead.

"Who's down there?" came a throaty shout from the other end of the alley.

Rubric snatched a heavy leather pouch from a wooden crate that stood next to Balo. "Thanks for paying full price, pal!

You're on your own!" Balo was left slack-jawed and holding the weapon as Rubric dashed in the opposite direction, making no effort to avoid knocking Flick to the ground as he made his cowardly escape.

"You shit!" Balo hollered at Rubric as he retreated.

"Town guard!" came a voice from the far end of the alley. "Surrender your sigils and amulets and place your casting palm firmly on the ground!"

"We need to go," Balo said, lifting Flick off the ground by his arm and hoisting him onto his back.

"Man overboard!" Zeet cried as he was flung from Flick's pocket. Thaddeus' tongue snatched the wingless fairy from mid-air and yanked him into the safety of Flick's mop. Zeet grabbed two fistfuls of

hair by the root.

Flick clung to Balo's back as his long strides approached the stables and the closed back door to the alchemist's.

"Hold on!" Balo shouted to Flick, and took a flying leap with his big boot aimed at the point where the two closed doors met. The wood around the latch cracked into splinters and the doors flew open with a bang. Flick was thrown from Balo's back and rolled; the leg that had broken the door came down hard on the knee. Balo stifled a pained scream and pulled himself to his feet.

"This is the town guard!" the voice repeated, closer this time and running. "Stop running immediately or forfeit all your arcane privileges permanently!"

"My door!" Yrda appeared from behind the

shelves, choking on a mouthful of pipe smoke. "You!" she pointed a golden claw at Flick, who scurried behind a pile of books.

"Out of the way!" Balo limped toward her, scanning the shop for Flick.

"Halt!" Yrda commanded, and brandished a vial filled with a golden liquid. "This is a smashglass of immolation. Stay where you are."

Balo aimed the barrel of the weapon at the alchemist. "This is a Remington Wingmaster. Step aside."

He spotted Flick's head rise above the books, eyes wide with anticipation, and added "If you please. Thank you very much. I'm very sorry about this."

Balo limped awkwardly around the

alchemist as the guard reached the door. A luminous chain of ether uncoiled from around the guard's arm, and he whipped the iridescent links in Balo's direction. The chain missed, smashing through a display shelf full of potions, sending its contents in all directions.

Yrda immediately retargeted his rage at the guard and sputtered as a long sequence of descriptive profanity bottlenecked in his mouth. The guard was equally tongue-tied with apology. He tried to gather the chain of ether, but a quick tug dropped it to a lower shelf and swiped it clean.

A milky blue vial rolled across the floor one step ahead of Flick as he ran for the front door, and he scooped it up without a thought.

"Come on!" Balo yelled, but Flick had

already passed him. The boy held the front door open so Balo could limp through while Yrda and the guard were distracted with one another.

Flick rushed to brace Balo. The two shuffled into the shadows away from the plaza and didn't slow down until they were out of Ixlin and nearing farmland once again.

"Let me rest," Balo grunted, and hopped to a rock that jutted out of the ground beside the road. "That did not go as planned. And your mother will probably fire me for getting you into so much trouble."

"I won't let her," Flick huffed, then was distracted by the glint of metal from the weapon Balo was carrying. "What is that thing?" he asked.

"Just a little old world magic," Balo

shrugged. He aimed it at the ghostly mountains in the distance. "I bought it."

"From Rubric? Why?"

"Yes. For protection."

"To protect the house?"

"And you, and your sisters. And your mother, who is probably sharpening the axe for my execution as we speak. Let's go. No more breaks until we're back home." Balo shoved himself off the rock and Flick returned to his side.

The moon was low, bright and yellow. Flick was captivated with this stark version of the landscape with shadows of barns and haystacks yawning across the fields. Zeet was introducing himself to Balo, who chuckled generously at the fairy's jokes.

Flick heard none of this because he was listening to the wind passing through the sparse trees and watching their shadows bob along the shadow of the line that ran over the road.

When they finally reached the Endriver home, Dyetta was standing outside with crossed arms. "You're in big trouble," she smiled. "What's that?" She pointed at the weapon in Balo's hand.

"It's nothing. Get inside, Dyetta," Balo grunted, removing his weight from Flick's shoulder and hopping toward the door. He tucked the gun discretely behind the coat rack. "Where's your mother?"

"She's not here," Dyetta followed them inside. "She went to find you."

"What? Why?" Balo demanded. "She knew we were going to town."

Ms. Endriver's friend Ms. May sat sleeping in a chair by the fire. "She's here to watch us while mother is gone," Dyetta grinned.

"Ms. May. Madam!" Balo raised his voice.

The woman awoke with a snort. "I wasn't."

"Ms. May, where did Radeka go?"

"She went to find her son. Oh! There he is."

"We'd have met her on the road. Which way did she go?"

"Well," Ms. May rubbed her eyes. "She was worried that Flick might wander off out of your sight before you noticed. You haven't got mother instinct, you know. And she was worried that Flick might want to try to go and see that awful creature. When it got

late and the other dinner guests started leaving, she became convinced that's just where he went."

"What awful creature?" Balo asked.

"Oh, you know. The one they talk about as if she's wise just because she's old. The alligator. Or crocodile. What was her name?"

"Kladramara," Flick answered.

"No, that's not it," Ms. May yawned. "Well, whatever it's called, that's where she went."

...

Tychus the spider was on his evening patrol when he spotted Radeka Endriver on the road with a lantern in one hand and a sword in the other. She rushed into the darkness with a look in her eyes that

Tychus recognized; he once saw it in the eyes of a mother wolf before she slaughtered a hunter who cornered her cub.

He ran along the line above her, barely able to keep up with her furious stride. When he could run no more, he leapt down from the line and landed silently on her shoulder.

"Good evening, Tychus," she said without flinching or slowing down. "I'm going to the swamp to find my son."

"I haven't seen him, madam, but I would very much like to offer my service as a guide."

"You know that I know my way, Tychus, as well as you do. Even after all this time."

"Of course. You think of those days often?"

"Don't you?"

"Constantly."

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